the Miyawaki method. EV charging stations are being planned in partnership with major private players. The Ayodhya Development Authority (ADA) is also working on climate-resilient drainage networks.



FLAGGING AN ISSUE

The biggest and most ambitious element is the 550-acre Navya Ayodhya township, meant to be one of UP's showstoppers. It will include a super-specialty medical centre, a 200-acre green area, a wellness hub, underground ducts for utilities and a hi-tech park. Beyond that, a museum on the temple is being planned. A 'Vedic forest' will recreate landscapes from ancient texts.

Takeaways

- **The 2024 loss in Ayodhya brought home the folly of relying on symbolism alone. The new mantra: governance now**
- **Blueprint: 550-acre Navya Ayodhya township, 40 MW solar plant along the Saryu, Miyawaki trees, EV stations**
- **As Ayodhya gets dressed up as a model city, Hindu seers slam *dharma dhwaja* hoisting as an improper ritual**

Being hyper-attentive to the city's political signals makes sense. UP is heading toward an assembly election in 2027, and Ayodhya holds a key place in the BJP's plans. As its best-known storyline, what happens in Ayodhya also matters far beyond UP's borders. The folly of relying on cultural symbolism alone having been shown up, the idea is to marry it to a model of modern governance.

But the cultural side of the debate—the *dharma dhwaja* ceremony, to be precise—is not entirely without friction. Several religious leaders have questioned aspects of the ritual. The Shankaracharya of Jyotirmath, a vocal critic of the BJP, says classical texts do not prescribe a flag-hoisting ritual and that the pinnacle's consecration is the actual culmination. None of the Shankaracharyas were invited to the event, a decision that further stirred debate among traditional clergy. Donors who contributed over Rs 2 crore, however, were invited. That added another layer to the conversation about the changing character of religious institutions aligned with the ruling establishment. ■

▶ JAMMU & KASHMIR

Demand For A Faith Quota

Kashmiri merit students taking most seats in Vaishno Devi board's new medical college sparks debate

By **Kaleem Geelani**

CHIEF MINISTER OMAR ABDULLAH may have restored the durbar move—the entire government migrating seasonally like a pastoral herd, out of a freezing Srinagar, into warmer Jammu. But the temperature gap is high for other reasons too. The Red Fort blast of November 10 shook up not just Delhi, it's ricocheting on Jammu-Kashmir ties too—in a way that may have national, constitutional implications.

The flashpoint: a significant intake of Kashmiri students at the brand-new Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Institute of Medical Excellence (SMVDIME) in Katra. Tension has peaked due to two reasons. The alleged suicide bomber was a doctor from Pulwama, and all his accomplices shared his profession as well as ethnicity. Two, the college is run by the Vaishno Devi shrine board.

SMVDIME got its green signal from the National Medical Commission (NMC) in September to start from the 2025-26 academic calendar, with 50 MBBS seats. The college, its main complex still under construction, opened in November. The 34-acre campus—sprouting in the lap of the Trikuta hills, at an altitude of 2,700 feet—also hosts a super-specialty hospital and a nursing college. The board, with liquid assets of Rs 2,000 crore, will have spent Rs 350 crore by the last coat of paint.

KASHMIR WINS SEATS

In short, everything was hunky-dory. But it so happened that nearly 90 per cent of the maiden batch—42 of 50 seats, to be precise—were taken by Kashmiri Muslims under NEET (National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test). And young freshmen doctors of that description are the exact cohort now seen with heightened suspicion. The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and its affiliates